Western imperialism—which inherited and expanded the legacy of coloniality. As scholars have pointed out, Western imperialism has proved to be a much more effective derivative of colonialism since it extended the territorial reach and depth of coloniality. Not only is the relationship of Western imperialism with other cultures the same as that of colonialism, namely ‘colonisation of the imagination of the dominated’, it has proved to be vastly more successful than colonialism in creating well-networked global power structures and totalising sub-frameworks that have sustained and advanced coloniality.[7] This is in stark contrast to colonialism which was much more territorial.

From the standpoint of preserving the continuity of coloniality, the Western-normative framework has delivered all the benefits of colonialism and more, without having to assume the same degree of burden and responsibility as colonialism, and with the added benefit of plausible deniability. While colonialism was more visible and direct because it required the subjugation of a population, the subterranean nature of Western imperialism has ensured that the dominated society aspires to become part of the erstwhile coloniser’s social fabric *after* decolonisation. As a consequence, scholars agree that coloniality remains the most prevalent and powerful form of domination in the world. This could not have become possible without sufficient investment by the coloniser in the political, religious, knowledge and legal systems of colonised societies, which were carried forward by decolonised societies.

Until the end of the Cold War in the late 1980s, that is, even after close to four decades of decolonisation, there was not enough rigorous scholarship that made sense of the nature of colonial power and its continuing impact on the life and polity of decolonised nations. The Cold War had demonstrated that despite decolonisation, erstwhile colonies were caught in the crossfire between superpowers who sought to dominate the world. Even those who claimed to be non-aligned, could not remain uninfluenced by the Cold War and its dynamics. It was during this period in the late 1980s that Peruvian sociologist Aníbal Quijano presented the concept of coloniality of power, specifically European power, which he distinguished from colonialism, as the very fount of colonialism. In other words, colonisation is the process, colonialism is the policy and coloniality is the mindset or the thought that underpins or drives colonialism.